

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 710

By Jones R

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of James W. "Jim" Ayers of Parsons.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of James W. "Jim" Ayers, a distinguished Tennessean whose legacy of business acumen, philanthropic leadership, and unwavering dedication to rural communities will endure for generations; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Ayers was the founder and chairman of FirstBank, which, under his leadership and vision, grew from a single bank with \$14 million in assets in 1984 to one of Tennessee's largest financial institutions, with over \$13 billion in assets and a footprint extending across the Southeast; and

WHEREAS, born on November 19, 1943, in Parsons, Jim Ayers came from very humble beginnings and embraced the values of honesty, hard work, and generosity and the importance of education instilled in him by his father, who worked in a sawmill and on the family farm, and his mother, who ran a fabric shop; and

WHEREAS, a self-described entrepreneur from the time he was eight years old, Mr. Ayers began earning money by shining shoes for ten cents a pair; at the age of ten, he was driving a tractor on the family farm and putting in eight to ten hours of labor on the weekends; and

WHEREAS, Jim Ayers spent a summer selling books for the Southwestern Company at the age of sixteen; traveling to McComb, Mississippi, he joined the company's summer sales force, staying in a boarding house while being paid ten dollars a week to knock on doors, selling mostly Bibles; and

WHEREAS, after graduating from Parsons High School in 1961, he attended Memphis State University, now the University of Memphis; during his sophomore year there, he started his family before receiving a degree in accounting in 1965; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Ayers began his career in the healthcare sector before founding American Health Centers, a network of forty nursing homes across Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, in 2006, he married the love of his life, Janet Ayers, who affectionately called him "Jimbo"; and

WHEREAS, his enduring legacy in banking began in 1984 with the acquisition of Farmers State Bank in Scotts Hill, eventually leading to his founding of FirstBank; Mr. Ayers served as Chief Executive Officer and later Executive Chairman of FirstBank, taking the company public in 2016, while never losing sight of the personal service and rural roots that defined his approach to leadership; and

WHEREAS, driven by a deep sense of purpose and guided by the biblical principle, "To whom much is given, much is expected," Mr. Ayers founded The Ayers Foundation in 1999 to improve the quality of life for Tennesseans through education, conservation, and social welfare; and

WHEREAS, through the Ayers Foundation, Jim and Janet Ayers's impact has been profound, directly supporting over 30,000 rural Tennessee students by helping them develop a plan to reach their goals, whether it be an apprenticeship, the military, a workforce certificate, or a college degree; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Ayers's generosity extended to many of Tennessee's educational institutions, including Jackson State Community College, where he served as an honorary member of the Foundation Board of Trustees, as well as Bethel University, Freed-Hardeman University, Union University, and the University of Memphis, all of which awarded him honorary doctoral degrees; and

WHEREAS, Jim and Janet Ayers's philanthropy extended further through the creation of the Ayers Institute at the Vanderbilt-Ingram Cancer Center, the Ayers Children's Hospital in Jackson, and the Ayers Institute for Teacher Learning and Innovation at Lipscomb University; and

WHEREAS, in recognition of the enduring impact that Jim Ayers made, Vanderbilt University Medical Center is naming its new \$500 million tower after Mr. Ayers; the Jim Ayers Tower is scheduled to open in October 2025; and

WHEREAS, his contributions to the civic and educational fabric of Tennessee earned him numerous accolades, including the Joe Kraft Humanitarian Award from the Community Foundation of Middle Tennessee, the Distinguished Alumni Award from the University of Memphis, the Silver Beaver Award from the Boy Scouts of America, Nashvillian of the Year by Easterseals of Tennessee, and induction into the Horatio Alger Association of Distinguished Americans and the Nashville Entrepreneur Center Hall of Fame; and

WHEREAS, Jim Ayers leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the life and legacy of James W. "Jim" Ayers, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mr. Ayers.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.